Final Project: Character Creation, Heart-Man

Character Introduction

Character Name and Backstory

The name of my protagonist is Brandon Klein. He is 21 years old and lives in the city of Constantine, an alternate reality version of Houston, Texas. He lives in an apartment with his alcoholic father, Jake Klein, who works a dead-end office job. Jake pays the rent and bills for their apartment as Brandon trained to become a Hero. Brandon's mother died during childbirth, and the only parent he knows is his father, a failed Hero. Brandon's desire to be a Hero is due to a desire to help the public, and to continue his father's dream. After high school, Brandon went to a Hero vocational school where he would learn martial arts and self-defense to prepare him for the local Hero Licensing test. The story begins after Klein graduates, and undertakes the Hero Licensing test to become Heart-Man.

Klein lives on the planet of Terra, on the supercontinent of Pangea. Pangea's existence is very similar to Earth's, down to the calendar system, as the story begins in the year 2025. Around the 1890s, humans began to appear with supernatural abilities known as Powers, and were labeled "Powered". In the present day, many Powered choose to become Heroes, dedicated government workers who serve the public good by assisting citizens, providing support in public events, and facing off against criminals, such as villains.

Brandon Klein is a Powered, and his power is "Above Average", which allows him to do anything a human can, but above average. He has above average (AA) athleticism, AA flexibility, AA senses, AA intelligence, AA endurance. As all his bodily systems are Above Average, they all combine and amplify each other to create a highly AA intuition, which grants him a Danger Sense. He chose the Hero name "Heart-Man" due to his audible heartbeat.

Character Obstacle

Brandon has a strenuous relationship with his father, Jake. Jake projected his beliefs and dreams into Brandon, which only amplified when Brandon manifested his Power at the age of 8. While Brandon is initially resolute in his desire to become a Hero, even going to a vocational school, taking the Hero Licensing test, and succeeding, it is once he becomes the Hero named Heart-Man that he realizes he doesn't know what route to take his career.

Becoming the Local Hero of Heart-Man, Brandon gets paid by the government approximately $70,000, and additional bonuses based on how many Powered criminals he takes down. With such a salary, Brandon becomes capable of leaving his father's apartment, which becomes more appealing, both for a desire to be independent, and because his father begins to drink more frequently, and progressively grows more annoyed about his Heroism beliefs.

Character Choice

Brandon has a choice in the end of Act I of the Heart-Man interactive story, to move into the content house of the Heroes of Constantine, or stay in the apartment and continue living with his father. If the player chooses to move in with the Heroes of Constantine, Brandon chooses fame and independence, and distances himself from his father. If the player chooses to stay in the apartment, Brandon loses a degree of independence, and doesn't get closer to his Hero acquaintances, but gains the capacity to confront his relationship with his father, and learns more about his father's philosophies.

This choice would be an orthogonal choice, and the direction of Heart-Man's career, life, and game, change dramatically with the decision. By going with the Heroes of Constantine, Heart-Man as an interactive media turns more bombastic and hedonic, but by staying in the apartment, more focus is placed on the civic aspects of Heroism, a more eudemonic experience.

Potential Resolutions and NPC Responses

The choice of content house vs apartment is one that's meant to round out the worldbuilding of Heart-Man, choosing between popularity and civics. In the world of Heart-Man, Hero Licenses have a range of what territory a Hero is allowed to work in, a ranking system of sorts. Local Heroes work in their respective city, State Heroes work in their respective state, National Heroes work in their respective country, and International Heroes work in multiple countries. By choosing to live in a content house, Heart-Man fast-tracks his career, but eventually loses contact with his father, and at the end, his father ends up disabled or dead due to a hostage situation. Heart-Man/Brandon thus loses his opportunity to resolve his relationship with his father in his route to becoming a well-known combat Hero.

If the player chooses to stay in the apartment with his father, his career progresses at a slower rate than it would have, but Brandon eventually comes to the resolution of figuring things out with his father, mending his relationship, and honing his belief of what it means to be a Hero. He is less close to his fellow Local Heroes as a result, and doesn't get offers for sponsorships or big events, but enough would happen in the interactive game itself that it doesn't become a government worker simulator.

If Heart-Man goes with the content house, he develops a rapport and friendship with the alter egos of Constantine's Local Heroes, while staying in the apartment means that Heart-Man has a strictly business relationship with the Heroes, and doesn't learn of their alter egos. Going the apartment route also allows Heart-Man to learn more about his mother, his father's past, and his short time as a Hero, and help rekindle his dad's old friendships.

Each story route would have multiple endings, and neither route is the "correct" one. The important part is developing each route to be equal in terms of value and weight.

Course Content Integration [CCI]

What Are Interactive Media?

Interactive Media is media where the audience can interact and cause a direct impact on the media they observe. A medium known for its interactivity are games, where the audience can directly participate on the rules established by its creators, such as sports like Football (soccer), board games like *Dungeons & Dragons*, or video games like *Super Mario Bros. Wonder*. That isn't to say that games are the only example of interactive media—famous TV shows known for their interactivity include *Dancing with the Stars*, *Big Brother*, and more, as these feature audience engagement, such as voting for a favorite contestant, or protecting a contestant from being kicked out.

The interactive story of Brandon Klein, of Heart-Man, would be titled *The Beat of Heart-Man*, and it would be a video game akin to the *Marvel's Spider-Man* game series or the *Batman: Arkham* series. It is a superhero semi-open-world action-adventure game in third person, and one plays as Heart-Man during the beginning of his career, assisting civilians, fighting crime, and doing important choices such as which Heroes Heart-Man befriends, entering romantic relationships, or training oneself to improve athleticism. I believe a video game format would help immerse a player into seeing the emotional spectrum of Heroism, from the benign to the thrilling, compared to a straightforward animated TV show or film.

Player Choices & Consequences

Choosing how Heart-Man determines to use his time, whether it is exercising, helping civilians with personal problems, participating in speeches, and engaging in various kinds of relationships, would be a crucial aspect of *The Beat of Heart-Man*. I visualize Heart-Man relying on a bulletin board in City Hall for civilian contracts (quests), a permeating presence (as it's

Heart-Man's job to be a Hero). Choices Heart-Man makes, such as helping certain civilians, or failing a contract, would be reminded to him throughout the story in subtle and unsubtle ways, like helping a sandwich shop with a crowded lunch hour, or doing PR work in a disadvantaged area. I want the player to be perpetually aware of the impact they're making in the city of Constantine, and this is most apparent with the meaningful choices made when interacting with fellow Heroes, or with Heart-Man/Brandon's father.

The orthogonal choice of going to the content house, or staying in the apartment is core choice of *The Beat of Heart-Man*, but other choices serve as the foundation of that choice, such as the immediate, uninformed choices found in an active crime scene, or the weighted choices of what Hero to date and dedicate time with. There will be obvious choices, such as taking on a contract that features an important plot beat, but overall, I want the player to feel as if their choices matter. This amount of emotional resonance is best possible through a video game.

Character Arcs and Shapes of Stories

The Beat of Heart-Man begins with the Hero Licensing test as the tutorial for the combat, and as a training ground for the player's perception of Heroism (as there's a written/ethics portion). Players see Brandon Klein's living conditions, a brief view of his past, and of his current skills that allow him to be accepted as a Hero, and the ability to grant himself the name of Heart-Man. The tutorial can be failed and has a bad ending. The obstacle for Heart-Man is, in a sense, the societal system he exists in—he faces off against Powered criminals and participates in mundane meetings, and finds that the public perception of Heroes is skewered toward the fighters. The beliefs that his father taught him, of the ideal Hero being a helper and public servant, are tested (especially since his father has a grating personality), and Heart-Man begins to re-examine his priorities. The choice of content house vs apartment is the big choice of the story,

and an early one at that, but it determines whether Heart-Man (initially) focuses on high-danger fame, or grounded civics. The player/Heart-Man's obstacle is ultimately which route of Heroism he wants to traverse, and once the big choice is passed through, Heart-Man will re-examine if that was the correct choice, and by the resolution, he can regret, or accept his decisions.

The Beat of Heart-Man features a New Testament/Cinderella story shape. There is a Creation Story climb as the player/Heart-Man takes on contracts, before the Act I choice turns the story arc rounded, higher, and more thrilling. Act II has more personalized fights based on the choice (fighting different Powered criminals), and have a similar, but different climax for Act III, as depending on how well one did as Heart-Man, the endings are hopeful, even if potentially bittersweet.

What Do We Want? What Do We Need? (Self-Determination Theory)

Brandon Klein's big Want was already achieved in the tutorial, as he passes the Hero Licensing test and becomes a Hero. However, as his Want is fulfilled, a new Want emerges, which is that of "What does it mean to be a Hero?", and obfuscates Klein's Need for Relatedness. The story's big orthogonal choice is a question of relatedness, as Klein determines his future relationships based on whether the player's perception of what it means to be a Hero, relates the most to fame, or to civic duty. According to Self-Determination Theory, prioritizing relatedness brings forth a desire to be understood, and as Heart-Man deals with his crisis for meaning and value in a superhero world, it brings into question what the player themselves value the most.

The theme of relatedness is particularly poignant, as Brandon/Heart-Man's power, Above Average, gives him amplified senses. This leads to Brandon commonly being overstimulated when feeling certain textures, being in loud environments, or in areas with intense smells. I'll be

blunt—Klein is in the Autism Spectrum. For those with autism, wanting to relate to others, such as those without autism, known as allistics, is a common value. Heart-Man believes that if he finds his meaning of what Heroism is, it will help him relate to his fellow Heroes, and perhaps to the greater public. It is up to the player to make those choices not just for him, but for themselves as well.

How Do We Like Stories? Enjoyment vs Appreciation

The two routes of *The Beat of Heart-Man*, the house route and the apartment route, each serve one of these types—the content house represents enjoyment, and the Apartment represents appreciation. If the player chooses the content house, they get exciting contracts, such as teaming up with Heroes to engage major crime syndicates, or have increased opportunities to fight Powered humans. If the player chooses the apartment, their contracts are more mundane, but there is more emotional introspection for both Heart-Man and his father, and the two progressively begin to understand each other. Heart-Man also gets opportunities to help more disadvantaged individuals that would otherwise be unable to send contracts to Constantine's City Hall.

Fighting supervillains and engaging in the dramatic relationships between humans with superpowers would inherently provide a more hedonic experience than helping the disadvantaged in society, which is a more eudemonic experience. Both sides are equally valid, and represent different aspects of the superhero genre, from the energetic (*Spider-Man: Homecoming*) to the thematic (*Logan*). As the nature of a story goes, there will be eudemonic moments in the house route, and hedonic moments in the apartment route, but I believe by splitting the tones of the story between the routes, the overall package of *The Beat of Heart-Man* is both hedonic and eudemonic.

How Do We Process People/Characters?

Cognitive misers indicate that our brains utilize mental shortcuts to save energy when interacting with life. There are certain ways that these shortcuts are activated, and these are through heuristics. The four key heuristics presented in Interactive Media Storytelling from strongest to weakest were Morality, Homophily, Sympathy, and Interdependence. Understanding how these apply to Heart-Man, the character players will spend time with the most, is crucial for his portrayal and writing in interactive media form.

Heart-Man glorifies Heroism, both due to how he was raised, and because his personality aligns with values such as honesty, justice, equality and equity. Because his morality is designed to be pure, players will see him as a positive and charming individual, although care must be taken to prevent players from perceiving Heart-Man as a goody two shoes. Heart-Man's homophily poses a complicated problem—as he is autistic, it is hard for allistic people to immerse themselves to his perspective, and thus emphasis must be placed for him to be appealing to many, such as a sense of humor that can make the player laugh. There is a decent degree of sympathy to be applied toward Heart-Man, as he lacked a mother, and his father placed an uncomfortable amount of pressure on him to become a Hero, even if Heart-Man was fine with it. This extends to Heart-Man's father, as his wife died, and his career as a Hero was a failure. Lastly, for interdependence, Heart-Man has highly AA intuition, so when translated to gameplay, a player can tell if someone is a good person or not, and decide their opinions accordingly. I believe a character like Heart-Man is hard to pull off, as his personality can appear too… good, but by granting him eccentricities and humor, he can be an entertaining protagonist.

Character & Narrative Schema

Heart-Man is as close to the hero ideal in a schema as possible. He's positive, loves assisting others, will prioritize other people's lives over his own, etc. A big wrinkle in that ideal is that Heart-Man is the type to escape when a situation turns dire, prioritizing saving others rather than brawling, due to the limits of his power. I view Heart-Man as having the beliefs of *Superman*, but having the physical capacities of *Spider-Man* without the web shooters, although Heart-Man does have his own version of Spidey Sense (through Danger Sense).

All other Heroes in the story are darker shades of heroic, veering to anti-hero territory, although they still primarily fight for justice and to preserve the well-being of society. For some (including Heart-Man), the content house serves as a means to an end, as some Heroes in the content house believe the publicity from participating in big battles would allow them to have more flexibility later in their careers. Heart-Man thus serves as an ideal which the player can choose to fulfill, or potentially betray, whether to seek fame or respect.

Showing vs Telling (Nonverbal Cues)

Brandon Klein is autistic. It is hard to find a balance between showing and telling, and Klein's autism (which I need to be careful not to present as Above Average compared to an allistic person) is something which I wish to present with a sort of obvious tact. Klein's mannerisms, his physical movements, his overstimulation, repeated movements, blunt manner of speaking, all show degrees of autism, but could be perceived as being due to his Power. Ways that I would confirm Klein's autism visually would be for papers he turns in during the Hero Licensing test (tutorial), and through infrequent mentions by other characters, such as "Oh, Heart-Man, you have autism, right? We're going to talk to some neurodivergent children." I want Heart-Man's Power to manifest itself through gameplay mechanics too, such as Danger Sense being visual cues in combat, or the ability to sense the danger of a location. I do not want his

abilities to be informed by the people around him, but rather for them to be integrated into both the gameplay and story properly.

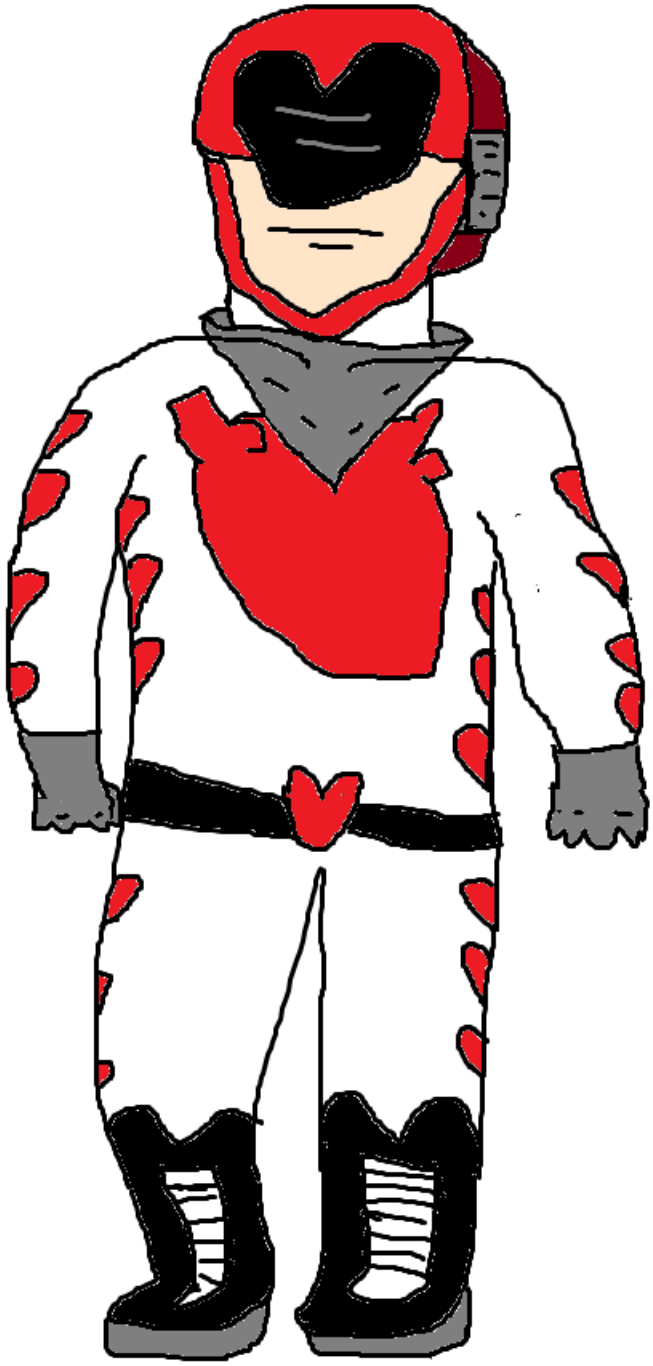
Affective Disposition Theory

I do not want my protagonist to be a bastion of goodness, but still be a representative of goodness despite his quirks and weaknesses. Through disposition formation, the player will believe in Heart-Man as a good person due to his behaviors, and through anticipatory responses, the player will want good things to happen to Heart-Man, despite the situations he finds himself in. Thus, despite this being a story about defining and learning one's goals, most of the endings should end off with a degree of hope, or of something "good" happening to Heart-Man, despite the routes he takes. Whether he focuses on fame and independence, or develops his Hero philosophy while improving his relationship with his father, something good must come out of both routes, in ways which are fulfilling for the player.

Intention, Action, Blame, Punishment

Lastly, the player is responsible for every action that they do as Heart-Man. If they choose to be antagonistic, hostile, and potentially evil, the choices made will remind the player of the path they're taking, and the ending for Heart-Man, no matter which route will not be positive. On a more subtle level, Heart-Man can do irrational seeming actions due to his AA senses (and autism), and thus he is likely to cause norm violations simply by trying to do good. He will be confronted, and many characters in-story may end up disliking him, but ultimately, much of what he does is for a desire to be a hero.

There will be times in the story where Heart-Man might suffer less repercussions through inaction rather than acting, as acting would result in a norm violation. If a player recognizes the hypocrisy of how society would treat a being like Heart-Man, then my job will be complete.



Heart-Man looks like this, but thinner. He has the helmet of a power ranger and the physical build of a Peter Parker. Also, his chin is supposed to be sharp.